

Solving difficulty

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Difficulty is an easy characteristic of problems but a hard one to expound. It may be defined as the element in the composition which serves to delay the solver from mastering the course of a solution. In longer problems difficulty is often found in the combinations, which elude the solver. In the two-mover difficulty almost always implies difficulty of key.

F.Gamage

I prize, Tidskrift for Schach 1909



Mate in two moves

Sometimes the position is so encumbered with a number of pieces that the solver is delayed in finding the key after investigating the purpose of many pieces.

The artistic element of difficulty is the 'try'. The composer may place his pieces in a suggestive grouping so that one method of attack draws the solver's attention and obscures the real solution. The converse of the try is paucity of attack. As there are no tries the problem is difficult to solve only because the solver will not know where to begin. Sometimes difficulty will come from unexpected sacrifice, flight giving key or changed mate. The two-mover by Gamage

(above) has two potential tries sufficient enough to distract solver's attention. Try 1.Qa4? Ra5! Try 1.Qxf3? Rd5! **Key 1.Qe1!!**

In the second diagram WB on d4 is obviously the key piece which threatens mate 2.Qd4 on the second move. But what is the destination square? **Key 1.Bf2!!** The tries 1.Bh8?/Ba7?/Ba1?/Bg1? are refuted by Rd7!/Nb6!/Nb2!/f2! respectively

Nils van Dijk, I Pr, De Schach 1961



Mate in two moves

The Meredith below is for solving
Lazlo Apro

I hm, Sah 1960



Mate in two moves

Solution to problem for solving in the article 'Direct unpin of black'

Key 1.Bd1!! ..c3 2.Qa6; 1...g3 2.Qxg3 1...Ne6 2.Qxf5

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